GRAMMATICAL RELATIONS

LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS

Phrases • Clauses • Verb Types • Argument Structure • Subject • Objects • Complements • Adjuncts • Heads

Learning outcomes

- Distinguish phrases from clauses and identify their heads.
- Classify common verb types by their complementation patterns.
- Explain argument structure, arguments, adjuncts and valency.
- Identify subject, direct object, indirect object and complements.
- Use grammatical diagnostics to justify an analysis.
- Apply the concepts to unfamiliar sentences.

Big picture: form → structure → function

FORM

Words combine into phrases; phrases combine into clauses.

STRUCTURE

Phrases have heads; clauses are organized around predicates.

FUNCTION

Grammatical relations include subject and object.

Example: The child opened the door with a key.
The child = subject • the door = direct object • with a key = adjunct

Grammatical relations vs. semantic roles

GRAMMATICAL RELATIONS

Subject, direct object, indirect object.

Defined by syntactic/distributional behavior.

SEMANTIC ROLES

Agent, Patient/Theme, Experiencer, Recipient, Goal, Instrument, etc.

Defined by participation in meaning.

Important: grammatical relations and semantic roles are related, but they are not the same thing.

Phrase: definition and structure

- A phrase is a constituent: a group of words functioning as a unit.
- A phrase is typically organized around a head.
- Examples: the very old house (NP); quite slowly (AdvP); in the garden (PP).
- Internal functions may include head, modifier, complement and determiner.
- Constituency can be tested using substitution, movement and coordination.

Clause: definition and structure

- A clause is a grammatical unit organized around a predicate.
- It may be finite or non-finite.
- Independent clauses can normally stand alone; dependent clauses cannot.
- Example: Mira bought a book yesterday.
- Clauses may contain subjects, arguments, complements and adjuncts.

Phrase vs. clause

PHRASE

A constituent headed by a category.

Examples: the red car; very quickly; in the room.

CLAUSE

Organized around a predicate.

Examples: He went home; I opened the room; She runs fast.

Key point: a clause contains both a subject and a verb, while a phrase does not have a subject-verb pair.

Heads and phrases

- The head is the central element of a phrase and determines its category.
- NP: the brilliant student → head = student.
- VP: quickly solved the problem → head = solved.
- PP: under the table → head = under.
- AdjP: extremely proud of her work → head = proud.
- AdvP: very carefully → head = carefully.

Lexical v/s Functional Phrases

- Lexical Phrases

-Carry the primary semantic meaning, imagery, and referential content.
-Nouns, verbs, adjectives, and adverbs come under this category.
-New words are constantly added to the language so are also called open class words.
-Can take suffixes and prefixes to change form (e.g., cat → cats, jump → jumped).
-Ex: In "The quick brown fox jumps over the wall.", the lexical words are quick, brown, fox, jumps, wall.

- Functional Phrases

-Establish grammatical relationships, show syntax, and link constituents.
-They include Articles, determiners, prepositions, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs, and pronouns.
-A fixed, limited set of words where new additions are extremely rare (e.g., you cannot easily invent a new preposition). So they are also called closed class words.
-They do not change form with prefixes or suffixes.
-Ex: In "The quick brown fox jumps over the wall", the functional word is The (an article), over (preposition).

Verb types

- Intransitive: Verbs that cannot or do not take objects.

Ex. The baby slept.

- Transitive: Verbs that take only one object i.e direct object.

Ex. The student opened the door.

- Ditransitive: Verbs that take both direct and indirect objects.

Ex. The teacher gave the student a book.

- Copular: Verb connects the subject of a sentence to a subject complement instead of showing an action.

Ex. The soup is hot.

Valency and complementation

MONOVALENT

One core argument:
The child laughed.

DIVALENT

Two core arguments:
The child kicked the ball.

TRIVALENT

Three core arguments:
The child gave the teacher a note.

Valency = the number and type of arguments a predicate licenses.

- Finite Verbs: A verb that shows tense (past, present, future) and matches the subject in number (singular or plural) and person (first, second, or third). It acts as the main verb of a clause or sentence and can stand alone as the root of an independent clause.

Ex: He plays football. (Present tense, singular subject)
They played football. (Past tense)

- Non-Finite Verbs: A verb form that does not change when the tense, person, or number of the subject changes. It cannot act as the main verb of an independent clause. Instead, it functions as a noun, adjective, or adverb.

Three Types:

1. Infinitives (to + base form, e.g., to eat, to learn)
   Ex: She wants to eat something delicious.
2. Gerunds (verb + -ing acting as a noun)
   Ex: Swimming is a great exercise.
3. Participles (verb forms acting as adjectives or helping build tense, ending in -ing, -ed, or -en)
   Example: The broken window let in the cold air.

Argument structure

- Argument structure describes the participants licensed by a predicate.
- Predicate = the central event, state or relation.
- Arguments = core participants associated with the predicate.
- Adjuncts = optional modifiers such as time, place, manner or reason.

Ex: Maya opened the window with a key this morning: the Maya and window are the core arguments; the other phrases are adjuncts.

Subject

- The subject is a major grammatical relation in English.
- It is commonly associated with agreement and nominative case.
- It often occurs before the finite verb in declaratives.
- Subjects can have different semantic roles: Agent, Experiencer, Theme, etc.
- Use several diagnostics rather than word order alone.

  -Find the Main Verb

  -Ask the Question "Who?" or "What?" directly before the verb.

  -Locate the Answer

Direct object

- The direct object is a core grammatical relation associated with many transitive verbs.
- Example: The researcher analysed the data.
- It can often become the subject of a corresponding passive.
- Object meaning varies: it need not be a literal 'receiver of action'.

Indirect object

- In English, an indirect object commonly represents a recipient or beneficiary.
- The teacher gave the student a book.
- the student = indirect object; a book = direct object.
- Compare: The teacher gave a book to the student.
- Terminology varies across grammatical frameworks.

Complements

- A Complement is a word, phrase, or clause that is required by the head to complete its meaning.
- Verb complement: She depends on her colleagues.
- Subject complement: She is a doctor.
- Object complement: They elected Maya president.
- Complement vs. adjunct depends on selection, construction and interpretation.

Adjuncts

- Adjuncts are optional modifiers adding information to a clause or phrase.
- Common meanings: time, place, manner, reason and frequency.
- Example: The students discussed the article after class.
- Adjuncts are often relatively mobile and can stack.
- Some boundaries are theory-dependent.

Worked analysis

The young researcher gave her supervisor a detailed report in the office yesterday.

- Subject: the young researcher.
- Verb/predicate: gave.
- Indirect object: her supervisor.
- Direct object: a detailed report.
- Adjuncts: in the office; yesterday.

Practice set

Identify the subject, object(s), complement(s) and adjunct(s) for each sentence.

A. The child broke the window accidentally.

B. Priya gave her brother a book yesterday.

C. The students became very excited after the announcement.

D. We put the files on the desk.

E. The committee elected Arun chairperson.

F. The old man carefully painted the wooden fence blue last weekend.

G. My sister became a successful lawyer after years of hard work.

H. They sent their parents a long letter from Paris yesterday.

I. The children found the hidden treasure under the big oak tree.

J. In the quiet library, the student considered the problem extremely difficult.

K. The young scientist quickly solved the complex equation on the whiteboard this morning.

L. After the storm, the villagers found their houses completely destroyed.

Q- (a)Give three examples each for intransitive verb, transitive verb, ditransitive verb, copular verb, finite verb, non-finite verb.

(b)Form sentences using them.

(c) Show the argument structure of the verbs in those sentences.

Common misconceptions

- Subject is always the first word. → Not universally true.
- Subject is always the Agent. → Subjects may be Experiencers or Themes.
- Every phrase after a verb is an object. → It may be a complement or adjunct.
- Every complement is obligatory. → Selection is more nuanced.
- Verb type determines semantic roles completely. → Syntax and semantics must be distinguished.